

Sony Ericssons Android

Sony Ericsson confirm Android v2.0 handset in the works

Blackberry serves

Blackberry Instant Message clients updated (AIM, Yahoo, GTalk, MSN)

Mobile Phone Test

ASUS P835

The P835 is ASUS' answer to large screen WM devices. With a 3.5-inch display, this unit is built very well. We really liked the good quality all-metal stylus, this does not have an issue with the end breaking off in the event of a drop. A very nice fitting back cover with an excellent lock slider-type mechanism, ensures that the phone will last for a good while owing to its metal parts. It's a large PDA and apart from the bezel along the sides, part of the rear and the screen itself, most of the phone is metal. The call-reject and power functions share a common key, while a Blackberry style trackball takes care of the joypad. We must say while being a novel idea for a Windows phone, and quite functional, this feature is very usable. We do wonder how long such a trackball would last given heavy usage and the fact that many Blackberry users complain about theirs. The screen is bright and crisp offering a high resolution with good detail. Based on the WM 6.1 platform and powered by a 528 MHz Qualcomm processor, the phone is fast and we never noticed anything slowing it down. Although the number keypad is very usable it's the QWERTY that people will find lacking about. On screen keyboards are largely gimmicky and not as productive as a hardware keyboard especially when it comes to heavy usage. The phone comes with 4 GB of in-built storage, and there is additional expansion via microSD supported. The five-megapixel camera is not much to write home about.

In-call performance is a bit below par for what is acceptable from a PDA phone where signal clarity is everything. The earpiece volume is decent however, as is the handsfree unit. Priced at Rs. 26,900 the P835 is actually a decent deal considering the HTC Touch HD's display is just 0.3-inches bigger and that phone is priced much higher, but in its defense it's a much better handset than the P835.



ASUS P835

Blackberry Storm 9500

The Storm is usually met with mixed reactions. Most corporate users scoff that the Blackberry has gone soft to the needs of multimedia users and has provided a touch interface that is deemed as hot and gimmicky. Other users would welcome the change from the strict QWERTY-based mold that all Blackberrys seem to follow. The phone's screen appears larger than its 3.25-inches. The handset is solidly built and the front is a typical glossy black with two non-glossy chrome strips running down either sides of the screen. The rear has a rubberised finish except for the battery cover that has a brushed aluminium texture, but in black. Overall the phone has a very classy, no-nonsense look. The menu buttons are cleanly laid out and along with the call buttons they form a straight line of buttons that runs the breadth of the phone. The entire screen can be clicked, and when touched with slight force the screen actually

moves inwards. This is meant to give feedback and it works. The on-screen number keypad is good but not so the alphabet keypad; once again this on-screen QWERTY touch keypad is not as good as the real thing. Touch gestures work well and scrolling through long emails is a pleasure.

Scrolling through menus is not as much fun as the phone tends to activate whatever menu the scroll stops on



Blackberry Storm 9500

rather than waiting for a second finger contact. There's a real quirk hidden in the menu system that rears its ugly head the moment when one tries selecting small icons or such. It's very difficult to get accurate on the screen and very often it's annoying to touch a particular function only to discover the phone activating/highlighting something adjacent to it.

The Storm 9500 has an excellent antenna and in call quality is really good. The handsfree unit is also very good and offers excellent clarity, although a couple of the Nokia phones beat it in this regard. The camera is present and offers barely acceptable results. The Storm has GPS with Blackberry Maps although weirdly there is no Wi-Fi available. Priced at Rs. 27,990, the Storm is a sexy device that will assure bragging rights and attention in any company. It's a really good handset. While the touch interface is functional it has the odd quirk.

Blackberry Bold 9000

The Blackberry Bold represents what a business PDA phone should look like. It's a very attractive device that's slightly wider and larger than other Blackberry handsets. The entire front and menu keys is in a glossy black. There is a non-glossy chrome rim running around the sides of the phone which houses buttons. That being said the buttons are clearly visible. The battery cover is huge and occupies the entire back of the phone. This cover has a leather texture that is genuine, a far cry

from the faux-leather finishes we've seen on some other devices. The menu and back buttons are large and nearly surround the white trackball. The call buttons are large and very easy to use. The 3.5-mm handsfree jack is located on the left side of the phone, below which is the mini-USB port. The voice command button is located underneath this and its location is the only possible quirk as it tends to get pressed easily while even

holding the device. Blackberry meant this button to be visible and usable so we're not sure whether to gripe or praise their design, but it does get unwanted use. The volume button is located on the opposite side of the device and despite its thinness and the flush fit, it's easy to use. The QWERTY keypad is absolutely wonderful. The keys are not really spaced out but the excellent bevelling makes it easy for your fingers to quickly glide over the keys. It's possible to really type fast on this device and it's better than the keyboard on the Blackberry Curve 8900 as well. The chrome strips running across the keyboard give the phone a classy look.

The menus on the Bold 9000 are well laid out and the phone is responsive. While the trackball can be set to glow when any message

is received or upon receiving an email or missing a call there's also a bedside mode that turns off any sort of distracting activity, except for the alarm — a real time saver, that.

What we like

about the menus is Blackberry's no nonsense approach to making everything available under one main menu and each setting is quite transparent with adjustments also requiring little or no effort to find and activate. The Bold 9000 is blessed with a sterling antenna and this device offers greater in-call clarity than even the Storm 9500, it however falls short of Nokia's excellent N95 8 GB. The earpiece



Blackberry Bold 9000

